If his party can slice away even 7-10 per cent of the vote, it could alter the outcome in dozens of constituencies, sending the electoral calculations of established parties into a tizzy, even if it does not necessarily win big itself. In this lies Kishor's strength—his potential to damage others.

The 7-10 per cent estimate is no conjecture. The first hint of Jan Suraaj's electoral strength came in October 2024, when the party contested four bypolls barely a month after its formal launch on October 2 last year. The results were instructive: no victories, but its candidate in Imamganj secured over 37,000 votes, enough to ensure the RJD's defeat. Across these constituencies, the party averaged 10.1 per cent of the vote share. Yes, not too grand for one party. But spread evenly across seats, a real likely spoiler.

WHAT ARE HIS CHANCES?

By PK's own admission, it's either "*arsh pe ya farsh pe*", either top or bottom, fewer than 10 seats or more than 150. That said, he does see an opening in Bihar's bipolar political world, where Nitish aligns with the BJP and the RJD with the Congress. For too long, he says, voters have been trapped in a cycle of choosing between Lalu Yadav's RJD (in a bid to keep out the BJP), or backing Nitish's BJP alliance, out of an aversion to the former.

PK also has a strategy for Jan Suraaj's pan-Bihar solo sorties. All 243 tickets will be distributed in such a way as to mirror the proportional strength of Bihar's castes and communities. Every social group, he says, will see itself reflected in the party's candidate list. "*Har samaj ko* population basis *par* representation *diya jayega*," he declares.

However, while his promise of tickets by proportional population sounds radical, the reality is a bit more complicated. Representation on paper does not guarantee mobilisation on the ground. A ticket to a caste candidate does not automatically translate into loyalty votes, especially when older networks of patronage, intimidation and social respect are already in place.

A section of the commentariat believes Jan Suraaj's rise will hurt Nitish and the NDA more than Tejashwi, since PK's political persona aligns more with the CM's 'good governance' plank that sits well with a savarna base. Even a section of BJP voters may back him over the JD(U), which will contest no less than 100 seats, for there is fatigue with Nitish and his 20-year tenure.

And while the RJD's Muslim-Yadav base looks near-unshakeable, PK has also begun to probe one of its flanks for weaknesses. The promise of proportional ticket distribution may play a role here. PK has also been at his most provocative while addressing this constituency. "You should fear no one other than Allah," he tells them. "Do not become the kerosene oil for RJD's lantern, merely to brighten Lalu's home." The line is both metaphor and indictment. He accuses the RJD of exploiting Muslim anxieties about the BJP, weaponising their fear to secure votes, while offering little in return.

PK is also inspired by Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) chief Chirag Paswan's 2020 score. He contested 135 seats, got only about 2.3 million votes and a solitary seat, yet could tilt dozens of contests. By cutting into the JD(U) support base, Chirag ensured Nitish was reduced to his lowest tally in two decades. The spoiler effect was undeniable: small shifts in vote share had outsized consequences.

DOUBLE OR NOTHING

Kishor's wager is that Jan Suraaj can replicate this, and on a far bigger scale. If Chirag could destabilise the status quo, then Jan Suraaj's targeted mobilisation across castes and communities might possibly redraw the state's electoral map. Political commentator Dr N.K. Choudhary, though, points to an obvious flaw in this idea. "Kishor does not have a committed voter base yet, so the impact will at best be marginal at this stage." Jan Suraaj's early outings attest to the potential, though, like the byelections late last year.

Meanwhile, Kishor, with his allegations against the JD(U)-BJP regime, has opened another front in the battle for Bihar. Reputations are fragile, and poll narratives are weapons. PK the disruptor has put both in play. The coming weeks will show whether his newly choreographed sequence can make more than headlines and win an election or two. ■

A S.W.O.T. FOR JAN SURAAJ

Strengths: **PK's agenda-setting ability, voter weariness with binary politics. Call to contest all 243 seats and caste-proportional ticketing bring additional twists in the poll drama**

Weaknesses: **Limited organisational depth, inexperienced leadership, no entrenched caste base and the modest vote conversion in the 2024 bypoll debut**

Opportunities: **In a state effectively alternating between Nitish and Lalu since 1990, PK offers a fresh alternative for voters. Could attract fence-sitters from both the NDA and Mahagathbandhan alliances**

Threats: **Being perceived as a spoiler that fragments established vote banks to the benefit of rivals; could marginalise Jan Suraaj**